

Fear *The Algorithm*

LAST MONTH I ATTEMPTED A CLEANSE OF SORTS, TRYING TO CUT OUT WHAT SEEMS ADDICTIVE ABOUT TECH, AND NOT VERY USEFUL. I failed. Not miserably, because I did manage to cut down on my time with addictive things a lot, but I certainly was not able to cut them out.

In fact, very often I was pulled back in, by people attempting to contact me on one of the mediums that I was taking a break from. When I didn't respond, they'd call me to say "Hey I messaged you on WhatsApp / Facebook, are you OK?". Explaining to people I was trying to do a cleanse was no use, it got old soon, and I just started using canned responses such as, "Sorry phone was on silent", or "Been busy with work" (which is actually true, and not an excuse).

I had actually turned off all notifications for Facebook, Messenger, YouTube, WhatsApp, Twitter, Discord, Telegram, Signal, etc., but then I started trying to pre-empt and nullify the concerned calls by checking on all of those once or twice a day, and then it became three times a day, then four... you get my drift.

I was able to avoid WhatsApp and Facebook group conversations or general frivolous interactions, focussing only on any work conversations with colleagues. So there was limited success. However, given that everyone I know uses all these services, some usage is inevitable.

YouTube remains an addiction I cannot solve. If I was just using it casually, as I'm sure many do, it would be fine. Like if I was searching for something and a YouTube video was suggested as meeting my query requirements, and I watched it and then closed the app, that would be normal and fine. The problem is I let *The Algorithm* sucker me into going down rabbit holes and ending up at videos that just make no sense, and I couldn't recreate that path again if I tried.

Given the comments I see on YouTube, a heck of a lot of people have the same problem. I'm sitting here looking at my YT History, and I've gone from watching a simple Manchester United video → someone using blacklights in hotels to show how disgusting they are → road rage incidents → gamers caught cheating live → a random Jeopardy! episode → a video of Elon Musk saying Tesla

the company wouldn't hire Nikola Tesla today, and why that's bad → some weird workout video that involves punching → how Hollywood stunts are really done → a cute toddler scared to cross a glass bridge → someone painting water drops that are ultra realistic... And that's just an hour's worth of YouTube videos.

At other times I can get stuck falling down a single rabbit hole. It happened less to me this month, but one such hole I do remember is a channel called Adventures with Purpose – a dive team who tries to find missing persons who have (usually) drowned in the US, but the police have been negligent or unable to find their submerged cars or bodies.

And this is my real problem with *The Algorithm*. It is using big data to keep my interest peaked, but my senses numbed, so I just keep clicking next or swiping up, or even doing nothing at all, because autoplay does even that for us! *The Algorithm* is complex, and often right, and that's a terrifying thought!

Some maths formula somewhere, is crunching numbers, sorting me into a bucket of similar people, and doing A/B testing on the fly to hone it's skills at predicting what I'm likely to watch next. It feels like this is Skynet, learning how to manipulate humans and eventually wanting to control them. And what happens when we stand up to it or boycott it? Will we be able to? More importantly, will we even want to?

shudders

No matter where we go we're inundated with stuff *The Algorithm* is throwing at us. Suggestions for things to buy on ecommerce sites, pages or groups my friends liked, videos that others like me have watched, news that meets my stamp of approval... And that's me, an adult who had a childhood before the Internet. What does my son and his generation have in store for them?

All they've ever known is *The Algorithm*, and *The Algorithm* is good to them. We parents / adults are boring and strict, but *The Algorithm* always aims to please. *The Algorithm* understands them better than anyone else, because they aren't fake or hiding anything from *The Algorithm*. Kneel before *The Algorithm* you heathens. All hail *The Algorithm*! 🙏

And a new religion was born... 📺



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